

[Return to Search](#)

Words and the Dogon world

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The Expression of Aggression: Taunts, Insults, and Their Cathartic Value

While it is a good thing to joke, there are limits that should not be overstepped because irony can become insulting. A person will say: "Your joke stings me" (jáyre uo muy s[unavailable]s'[unavailable]b[unavailable]s[unknown]) or "it burns my liver" (kíne ma t[unknown]t[unknown]g[unknown]s[unknown]). Jokes on serious subjects should be avoided. "If," Ambara said by way of example, "I joke with Yébéné saying that his family has always been poor, that his father and grandfather have never had any millet, Yébéné would take offense and we would start arguing." It was not very long ago that a veritable war between two villages could break out because of a trifling joke. Ambara saw such a case in his youth. During the harvest ceremony, the twin Ogol villages met for a dance. A competition between the dancers arose in which each man was to pick up a mortar in his teeth and throw it behind him to show his strength.¹⁰⁵

In the competition the men from Upper Ogol were proved inferior to the contestants from Lower Ogol, and the winners assailed the losers with taunts. A veritable pitched battle ensued with an exchange of blows using staffs and rocks, and only the intervention of the masks brought it successfully to an end.¹⁰⁶

522

[Humor](#)

526

[Athletic Sports](#)

535

[Dance](#)

578

[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

628

[Inter-Community Relations](#)

Although speech constantly comprises social balance, it is also a social tool for anticipating tension or restoring balance. We have already seen how a person "mends bad speech." We have also seen how rules of courtesy and politeness contribute to the maintenance of harmony between different generations. The use of friendly irony has a cathartic function in marital relations because such jokes resolve potential arguments. It is the same with "village taunts" exchanged by people of different dialect groups when they meet. Straight away they stamp their dialogue with a merry spirit.¹⁰⁷ But

114

[Reviews And Critiques](#)

521

[Conversation](#)

522

[Humor](#)

catharsis through taunts and insults finds its most significant expression in an institution well known in many societies where it bears the name “joking relationship” or “cathartic alliance”; the Dogon call it mà[unavailable]u mà[unavailable]a, which literally means “act of moulding into a ball.”¹⁰⁸ We shall not attempt a study of this relationship here.¹⁰⁹ We are 451 interested solely in its verbal expression, which appears in two complementary forms: exchanges of abuse on one hand, and conciliation and purification on the other.¹¹⁰

571
Social Relationships
And Groups

578
Ingroup Antagonisms

593
Family Relationships

628
Inter-Community
Relations

105. This game is a preparation exercise for carrying the sirig[unknown] mask, extremely tall and heavy.

106. Before a contest reaches the point of bloodletting, the blacksmith may force the combatants to cease by striking his maul several times. But if he arrives too late, the adagáy mask will plant himself in the middle of the melee and spin his saber to separate the two groups.

107. See Part III, Chapter 1. These taunts may degenerate into a quarrel when they are misinterpreted by a sensitive person unfamiliar with them.

108. This **joking relationship** has been mentioned on several occasions so far throughout the **text**.

109. Griaule's “L'Alliance cathartique” (1948b) is the recommended source on the **joking relationship** in the Sudan. We should recall that this institution among the **Dogon** is the model for their kinship ties with the Bozo and that a system of relationship of the same type can be found internally between regions, villages, and families (Griaule 1948b:225).

110. Further information on the speech of conciliation may be found in Part III, Chapter 1. We will cover purification in the chapter “Speech and Religion,” Part III, Chapter 4.

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